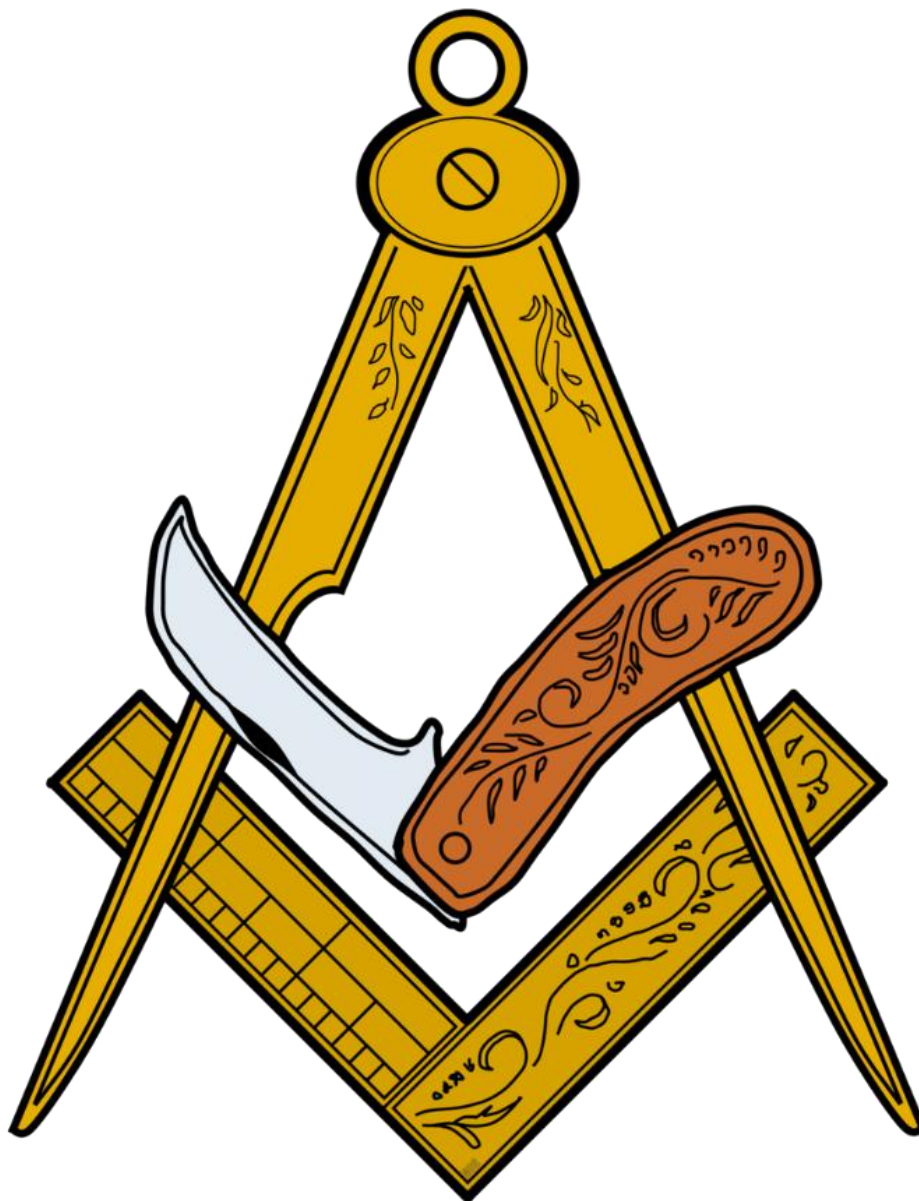


THIRD DEGREE LECTURE

THE FREE GARDENER MASTER



[Authorized by the United Council, A.O.F.G., Inc.]

Why Free Gardening Calls for Initiative:

In the third degree, the Master Gardener is led four times to the table of the Worthy Master. In the garden, no table is considered an altar except for the one beneath the unadorned rose arch. This altar represents the altar built by Noah after the Flood (Genesis 8:20) and is known as the “altar in the west” or the “western altar.”

The fact that the Worthy Master’s table in the east is not an altar is emphasized by the rule that it must not be higher than any other table in the garden. It stands at the same height as all the others and is therefore equal to all brothers and sisters.

The “altar in the west” is the ancestral place of the three roses and the olive branch. These symbols are called “The Four Parables of Paradise,” or simply “The Four Parables,” because they originate from the Garden of Paradise—and only they may rest upon an altar.

	1 st Degree	2 nd Degree	3 rd Degree	4 th Degree
The Four Parables of Paradise	Pink Rose	White Rose	Red Rose	Olive Branch
Spiritual Virtue	Faith	Hope	Love	Fulfillment

The rose arch also symbolizes the rainbow from the Old Testament Flood narrative (Genesis 9:8–17). For this reason, although it is called a rose arch, it bears no flowers or decorations. As in the Apprentice Degree of the Free Gardener, the Seeker is brought four times to the Worthy Master’s table in the East.

In the Apprentice Degree, this first occurs during the division of the lights—when the seeker kneels before the four great lights of Free Gardening: The Bible, compass, square, and pruning knife. The Bible must lie apart from the Free Gardening tools because it is the greatest of them all.

There are six Free Gardening tools in total:

- **Three in the East:** compass, square, pruning knife
- **Three in the West:** spade, rake, scythe

	1 st Degree	2 nd Degree	3 rd Degree	4 th Degree
The Four Great Lights	Compass	Square	Pruning Knife	Bible
Tools of the East	Compass	Square	Pruning Knife	
Tools of the West	Spade	Rake	Scythe	
Spiritual Virtue	Faith	Hope	Love	Fulfilment

The First Time: In the presence of the lights in the East, the apprentice sees the light that has been denied to him since his earthly birth. Two strong hands hold him from behind, so he does not fall back into darkness. The Instruction Master stands behind him and says, “Beware of temptation and the wiles of the Evil One.”

The Instruction Master deliberately stands between the archetype of the apprentice degree—the “serpent” on the green carpet of work—and the seeker. For every outdoor gardener has vowed:

“Support, encourage, and protect our sisters and brothers wherever you can. Strive earnestly, sincerely, and zealously for the friendship of every member”.

The Instruction Master’s action embodies that vow in its strongest form. From this moment on, the seeker becomes a brother or sister, for the Worthy Master says for the first time, “Arise, my brother/sister.”

The Second Time: The unblindfolded Free Gardener Apprentice is led to the Worthy Master’s table. There, he kneels again and takes the vow.

The Third Time: The apprentice receives ceremonial clothing and puts on the apron himself, just as he later puts on the cuffs in the Master Degree. In both the first and third degrees, these actions symbolize self-initiative—just as Adam and Eve clothed themselves with fig leaves (Genesis 3:7). Their act of covering themselves in shame mirrors the story in the Journeyman Degree, where Shem and Japheth cover their father Noah’s nakedness with the deepest reverence.

The Fourth Time Before the Worthy Master’s table, the apprentice receives instruction in the four modes of recognition: sign, token, word, and motto. The significance of the number Four in Free Gardening requires no special explanation here; it will be addressed more fully in a future lecture.

Ceremonial Acts in the Master Gardener Degree:

In the Master Degree, the journeyman is **first** led to the Worthy Master’s table to make his vows. This is the first time one is led to the East in the Master Gardener Degree.

For the **second** time, he receives the two arm cuffs, which signify, among other things, that operative gardening has ended and the art of symbolic gardening has begun. The new Master Gardener puts on both cuffs himself: the left for the heart (*Emotio*), the right for the mind (*Ratio*).

The Third Time he is led to the table in the East, touches his apron with the square, and places it upon the Bible. The arrangement must be consciously perceived, though the seeker can scarcely do so in such an extraordinary moment. Before he is asked to perform this act, the three “Tools of the East”—compass, square, and pruning knife—are arranged on the Master’s table as in an Apprentice Lodge. Everything is done solely on behalf of, in the name of, and in harmony with the Apprentice Lodge.

After placing the square on the Bible, the Worthy Master hands him the compass, with which he touches his sash before placing it over the Bible. The square is already positioned there. Finally, he takes the pruning knife from the Worthy Master, touches his left arm sash with it, and places it over the Bible, square, and compass. From the seeker's perspective, the knife blade now rests on the right side, and the compass lies beneath the square.

Through this act, the new Master Gardener not only consecrates himself but also makes a personal commitment to himself, the Lodge, and the Supreme Gardener of the Universe—the Free Gardener's name for God—expressed in these words:

“They grow together and support one another. Some shield their companions from the harsh northern winds; others offer relief from the scorching sun. In their unity, they protect and uphold each other. This is the natural strength of a like-minded fellowship. This is why we join such a worthy fraternity: to shield each other from storms of adversity and to ease the suffering of those in need”.

One should remember:

- If the knife blade is placed on the left, it represents an organization (Apprentice Lodge, Master Lodge, etc.)
- If the blade is placed on the right, it represents a person of the corresponding degree

Finally, his **Fourth Time** before the Worthy Master's table, the new Master receives instruction in the four modes of recognition of the Master Gardeners: sign, token, word, and motto. The unbroken chain of Free Gardening tradition is carried by the Worthy Master to every seeker—from the beginning of the Order to the end of days, the fulfillment of the eighth day of creation.

If earlier degrees only hinted at self-initiative, in the Master Gardener Degree it is expressed unmistakably and permanently through this ceremonial act.

Therefore, the Worthy Master's final words in every degree are:

“Go out into the world and plant seeds of harmony, peace, and friendship among the people.”

These words can be interpreted as symbolic in earlier degrees, but from the Master Gardener Degree onward they are no longer merely symbolic—they are a charge to be lived.